

CROWS



CROWS AND THEIR RELATIVES are intelligent and noisy birds that are sometimes found in flocks. They are most widespread in the northern hemisphere and are often common in woods and farmland. Some species can be found in gardens and backyards. Birds in the crow family are not specialized for one particular way of life and this allows them to make the most of different kinds of food. Many of them will eat almost any kind of food that they come across, including young birds.



Blue jay
Measuring 28 cm (11 in) long, this brightly coloured bird is one of the smallest species in the crow family. It lives in eastern North America.

Common raven
Ravens are the largest members of the crow family. They live in remote places, such as mountains and rocky coasts, and have a deep, croaking call.

Powerful beak can tear open the bodies of dead animals.



Carrion crow

This widespread crow lives throughout Europe and much of Asia. Like most crows, it is a great opportunist, and often feeds on the remains of dead animals that have been run over on roads.

Glossy black plumage

Broad wings used for soaring high.



Powerful legs covered with large scales.

Feeding

Crows have strong beaks, but compared to many birds they are not fussy about what they eat. They are fond of seeds, worms, and insects, and in spring they sometimes eat the eggs and nestlings of other birds. They are determined feeders. Farmers try to scare them off with scarecrows or shotguns; small birds have more difficulty keeping them away.



Seed eaters

Unlike most members of the crow family, some jays live mostly on the seeds of oaks, pines, and other trees. They collect seeds during the autumn, and then bury them. These seed stores provide food for the winter.



Nest robbers

Magpies make life difficult for small birds by raiding their nests. Magpies are cumbersome and, despite their large size, quite timid. They rarely plunder nests that are constantly guarded.

Azure-winged magpie

This magpie lives in two different areas of the world: China and Japan, and Spain and Portugal. Some people think it was brought to Europe from Asia long ago. Others think it once lived all over Europe and Asia, but disappeared from many areas because of climate changes.



Long tail gives the magpie manoeuvrability in the air.

Carrion eaters

Ravens search for food by flying high over open ground, just like birds of prey. Instead of killing animals, they usually eat ones that are already dead.



Social groups

Ravens, jays, and magpies often live on their own or in pairs, but some members of the crow family spend their lives in large flocks. This way of living makes it easier for the birds to defend themselves against predators, and also increases their chances of finding food.



Jackdaw hierarchy

These small but boisterous crows come from Europe and western Asia. They live in groups in which there is a strict hierarchy. They are good at living near humans and often nest on buildings.



Rooks

These birds build their nests at the top of high trees, and they gather together as the sun begins to set. These nesting sites are called rookeries. The same name is used to describe breeding groups of many other animals, from penguins to seals.

COMMON RAVEN

SCIENTIFIC NAME *Corvus corax*

ORDER Passeriformes

FAMILY Corvidae

DISTRIBUTION North America, Europe, northern and central Asia

HABITAT Mountains, moorland, and rocky coasts

DIET Seeds, small animals, and animal remains

SIZE Length: 64 cm (25 in)

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